

NERVOUS-SYSTEM & PHYSICAL RECOVERY MANUAL

A science-based guide to rest-state recovery, sensory regulation, movement, sound, heat, nutrition, bodywork, nature and complementary practices

This guide is for periods of severe fatigue, sleep deprivation, prolonged stress, hyperarousal, shutdown, muscular guarding, sensory overload, brain fog, or the feeling that the body simply will not come back down to baseline.

The nervous system is not a single “on/off switch.” Recovery involves interactions among the autonomic nervous system, hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal stress system, circadian clock, immune system, muscles and connective tissue, cardiovascular system, sensory systems, metabolism, and brain networks involved in threat detection and attention.

Some practices below have reasonably good physiological evidence. Others have promising but preliminary research. A few—such as crystal healing, “water memory,” and some interpretations of earthing—belong primarily to spiritual or ritual traditions and have not been scientifically demonstrated to work through the mechanisms commonly claimed for them. I include them because they can still function as meaningful rituals, sensory anchors, or intentional practices without misrepresenting the evidence.

1. MORNING LIGHT: RESETTING THE MASTER CLOCK

One of the most biologically powerful things you can do costs nothing:

GET OUTSIDE AFTER WAKING.

Light entering the eyes is detected by specialized retinal cells that communicate with the suprachiasmatic nucleus (SCN), the brain's primary circadian clock.

That clock helps regulate:

- Melatonin
- Cortisol timing
- Body temperature
- Alertness
- Digestion
- Sleep pressure
- Hormonal rhythms

Morning bright light tends to shift the circadian system earlier, helping the brain establish a

clearer distinction between biological day and biological night. NIH guidance uses appropriately timed morning bright-light exposure as a treatment for certain circadian rhythm disorders.

PRACTICE

Within roughly the first hour after waking, go outside if possible.

You don't need to stare at the sun. Do not stare directly at the sun.

Simply expose your eyes to ordinary outdoor daylight.

Cloudy outdoor light is generally still much brighter than ordinary indoor lighting.

Combine it with:

Water

Breakfast

Gentle walking

Stretching

Qigong

That creates a powerful cluster of “day has begun” signals.

2. YOGA NIDRA: REST WHEN YOU CANNOT SLEEP

This belongs much higher on the list than ordinary meditation when someone is exhausted but unable to actually fall asleep.

Yoga Nidra is a guided practice normally performed lying down. Instead of trying to concentrate intensely, you're led through body awareness, breathing, imagery and progressive withdrawal from external stimulation.

A 2025 systematic review of six randomized controlled trials found promising improvements in measures including sleep onset, total sleep time and sleep efficiency, although the studies were small and had methodological limitations. It is promising—not a scientifically established substitute for sleep.

WHAT IT MAY BE USEFUL FOR

You're sleep deprived.

Your body is exhausted.

But your brain keeps scanning/thinking.

Trying harder to sleep is making you more activated.

In that situation, the objective becomes:

STOP TRYING TO FORCE SLEEP. CREATE A LOW-AROUSAL REST STATE INSTEAD.

PRACTICE

Lie completely supported.

Dark room if possible.

Headphones or speaker.

Search:

Yoga Nidra 20 minutes

or:

Yoga Nidra deep rest

Then make an agreement with yourself:

I don't have to sleep. I'm just going to stop doing everything for 20–30 minutes.

If sleep happens, great.

If not, you've still spent that period reducing sensory demands instead of pacing, scrolling or fighting insomnia.

Important: Yoga Nidra cannot physiologically replace the full functions of adequate sleep. Treat claims like “30 minutes equals four hours of sleep” as marketing rather than established neuroscience.

3. SOUND REGULATION: THE AUDITORY NERVOUS SYSTEM

Sound isn't merely something we consciously hear.

Auditory information interacts with systems involved in:

Attention

Arousal

Emotion

Memory

Motor timing

Respiration

Autonomic regulation

A 2026 meta-analysis of 24 randomized trials involving 1,295 people found music interventions changed several heart-rate-variability measures, with particularly notable

effects among people experiencing stress/anxiety/sleep-related problems. Participant-selected music sometimes performed better than standardized music.

That means attunement matters.

The most regulating sound may not be the frequency someone on YouTube claims is universally therapeutic.

It may be:

The song your body associates with safety.

Rain.

A low drone.

Drumming.

A voice.

Silence.

A bowl.

Chanting.

BUILD A SOUND ENVIRONMENT

For hyperarousal:

Slow predictable music

Low-volume drones

Rain

Ocean

Brown noise

Soft chanting

For shutdown/lethargy:

Rhythmic percussion

Upbeat familiar music

Movement + sound

Singing

The nervous system often responds to rhythm and predictability.

4. SINGING BOWLS

Singing bowls are more scientifically interesting than dismissing them as “just woo,” but claims still outrun the evidence.

A 2025 systematic review identified 19 clinical studies, including nine randomized trials, and found preliminary evidence for effects on anxiety, depression, sleep and several physiological measures. Another systematic review found promising results but emphasized substantial methodological limitations.

A newer review also reported that studies have observed changes in measures including heart rate, HRV and brainwave activity, but heterogeneity remains substantial.

POSSIBLE MECHANISMS

Rather than assuming the bowl is “clearing energy,” scientifically plausible mechanisms include:

- Auditory entrainment
- Focused attention
- Reduced environmental complexity
- Slow breathing during listening
- Expectation/placebo effects
- Meditative state
- Low-frequency vibration felt through the body

PRACTICE

Strike or circle the bowl.

Let the entire tone decay before striking again.

Close the eyes.

Feel both:

sound through the ears

and

vibration through the body

10–20 minutes is plenty.

5. TUNING FORKS

Tuning forks produce extremely predictable vibration at a defined frequency.

There is far less clinical evidence for standalone tuning-fork healing than the wellness industry sometimes implies.

A recent small randomized trial tested a combined intervention involving Tibetan singing bowls, tuning forks and other components and reported reductions in distress and physiological arousal, but because multiple methods were bundled together, it cannot prove that tuning forks themselves caused the effects.

Scientifically, tuning forks are most defensible as:

focused auditory stimulation + tactile vibration + attentional anchor.

Use them as a sensory regulation tool, not as a proven treatment for organs, DNA, electromagnetic injury or specific diseases.

6. HUMMING, CHANTING & THE VAGUS NERVE

This one has an actual physiological rationale.

The vagus nerve is a major parasympathetic pathway connecting the brain with organs including the heart, lungs and digestive tract.

During humming or prolonged chanting, several things happen together:

Your exhalation becomes longer.

Respiration becomes slower.

The larynx vibrates.

Auditory feedback becomes repetitive.

Attention narrows.

Slow respiration itself strongly affects cardiovascular rhythms.

Small studies of audible chanting have shown changes in heart-rate variability associated with autonomic modulation, although researchers cannot yet cleanly separate vibration from breathing, meditation and training effects.

A tiny fMRI pilot study of OM chanting also observed decreased activity in several limbic/paralimbic areas, including the amygdala, although 12 subjects is nowhere near enough to make sweeping clinical claims.

PRACTICE

Breathe in normally.

Hum during the entire comfortable exhale:

mmmmmmmmmmmm

Feel vibration around:

Lips

Nose

Face

Throat

Chest

Then inhale naturally.

Try 5 minutes.

Don't hyperventilate.

TRAUMA RESPONSE USE

If silence makes your thoughts louder, sound gives the nervous system something external and rhythmic to organize around.

You don't necessarily need OM.

Hum.

Sing.

Pray aloud.

Chant.

Read something slowly.

The combination of voice + breath + vibration + rhythm is the useful part.

7. STRETCHING: MUSCLES TALK TO THE BRAIN

Stretching isn't merely lengthening a piece of meat.

Muscles, tendons and joints contain sensory receptors continuously sending information toward the spinal cord and brain.

This sensory system contributes to proprioception—your brain's ongoing model of where the body is and what it is doing.

Slow stretching changes:

Muscle tension

Joint position

Proprioceptive input

Breathing pattern

Attention to internal sensation

A study of yoga-style stretching found decreased salivary cortisol and increased measures associated with parasympathetic activity after the practice, with some effects continuing afterward. That's intriguing, although it was a relatively specific intervention and shouldn't be generalized to every kind of stretching.

WHY THIS MATTERS AFTER STRESS

Chronic threat can produce muscular guarding:

Jaw tight.

Shoulders elevated.

Abdomen clenched.

Hands tight.

Hips rigid.

Stretching sends different sensory information back to the brain:

the body is moving freely rather than preparing for impact.

RECOVERY STRETCHING

Don't aggressively force range.

Hold gently.

Breathe.

Try:

Neck.

Jaw.

Chest opening.

Shoulders.

Hip flexors.

Hamstrings.

Calves.

Spinal rotation.

30–60 seconds at comfortable intensity.

8. QIGONG

Qigong combines:

Slow coordinated movement

Breathing

Attention

Posture

Body awareness

Its strength for an overloaded person is that it doesn't demand stillness.

You're regulating through controlled movement.

NCCIH describes evidence around qigong/tai chi as promising for some outcomes but inconsistent depending on condition and study quality. They are generally low-risk when practiced appropriately.

GOOD START

Search:

8 Brocades Qigong beginner

This gives you a repeatable sequence without requiring equipment.

9. TAI CHI

Tai chi adds more continuous weight shifting, posture and balance.

This means the brain must continuously process:

Joint position

Weight distribution

Movement direction

Breathing

Visual orientation

Balance

It's almost moving sensory integration.

Studies suggest tai chi may improve sleep quality and some stress-related outcomes, although evidence varies by population.

Use it when sitting meditation makes you feel trapped or restless.

10. WEIGHT & DEEP PRESSURE

Some people calm dramatically under:

A heavy blanket.

Firm pillows.

A tight hug.

Compression.

A weighted lap pad.

This is usually discussed as deep-pressure stimulation.

A 2024 randomized pilot study involving 102 adults with insomnia found weighted blankets improved subjective sleep quality and several related symptoms compared with ordinary blankets, although objective actigraphy differences were more limited. Another randomized study involving psychiatric populations also found substantial improvement in insomnia symptoms.

CHEAP VERSION

Layer blankets.

Hug a heavy pillow.

Place pillows tightly alongside the body.

Use a folded comforter across the legs.

Pressure should feel containing, never restrictive.

Do not use a weighted blanket on someone who cannot remove it independently or where breathing, circulation or mobility makes it unsafe.

11. TEMPERATURE AS A NERVOUS-SYSTEM SIGNAL

Temperature is processed by sensory pathways feeding directly into homeostatic brain systems.

That is why changing temperature can rapidly change subjective state.

WARMTH

Can reduce muscular guarding and create strong safety/comfort associations.

Try:

Warm bath

Heating pad

Warm blanket

Warm shower

Warm tea

COOLING

Can increase alertness and interrupt escalating sensory/emotional activation.

Try:

Cool cloth on face.

Cool water on hands.

Cooler room.

Brief cool shower.

Avoid extreme ice exposure when medically vulnerable.

HEAT & AUTONOMIC FUNCTION

Heat exposure affects cardiovascular/autonomic regulation, but effects depend heavily on intensity and whether the heat is local or whole-body. Research shows that strong whole-body heat can temporarily increase sympathetic demands, while some sauna protocols may produce different autonomic effects.

So don't interpret every sauna session as instant “parasympathetic healing.”

Heat is physiological stress followed by recovery.

12. SWEATING / SAUNA

Sweating primarily exists to cool the body.

It's not your main detoxification pathway.

Your liver and kidneys do most chemical processing and elimination.

However, sauna can still be valuable because it produces:

Heat exposure

Vasodilation

Cardiovascular challenge

Muscle relaxation

Quiet/rest

A strong subsequent cooling/recovery period

LOW-COST VERSION

Warm bath.

Hot shower.

Exercise until comfortably warm.

Sun warmth—without overheating or burning.

IMPORTANT

If already:

Dehydrated
Faint
Extremely sleep deprived
Vomiting
Ill
Heat intolerant

adding intense sauna may be the opposite of recovery.

13. SALT BATHS

A warm salt bath provides three separate experiences:

HEAT

HYDROSTATIC PRESSURE

SENSORY/RITUAL ENVIRONMENT

Epsom salts contain magnesium sulfate, but claims that significant quantities of magnesium reliably absorb through intact skin are not well established.

That doesn't make the bath useless.

The bath itself is the intervention.

Try:

Warm—not dangerously hot—water.

Dim light.

Epsom salt or ordinary bath salt.

Sound.

20 minutes.

Then hydrate.

14. WATER & “WATER MEMORY”

This needs careful separation between physics and ritual.

The idea that ordinary drinking water permanently stores intentions, words, emotions or molecular “memories” in a way that then produces demonstrated medical effects is not established by mainstream chemistry or biomedical evidence. One scientific review specifically argues that persistent “water memory” is incompatible with what is known about liquid water's rapidly changing molecular structure.

However:

SPEAKING INTO WATER CAN STILL BE A RITUAL

Hold the glass.

Slow down.

Say:

Let this be the moment I begin recovery.

Then drink.

Scientifically, the likely active components are:

Attention.

Expectation.

Meaning.

Behavioral cueing.

Hydration.

Breathing.

Ritual.

That's not nothing.

Human nervous systems respond strongly to meaning and expectation.

You don't have to claim the hydrogen bonds recorded your sentence.

15. WATER IMMERSION

Being submerged changes physical input dramatically.

Water provides:

Uniform pressure

Buoyancy

Temperature change

Reduced gravitational loading

Strong tactile input

Possible options:

Bath.

Pool.

Lake.

Ocean.

Float tank.

Even simply putting feet in water can provide strong sensory input.

16. BODIES OF WATER / “BLUE SPACE”

There's now a real research literature around blue spaces—oceans, rivers, lakes and other water environments.

A 2026 systematic evidence map identified a large body of research connecting blue-space exposure with various mental-health and well-being outcomes, although study methods and strength vary considerably.

Possible mechanisms include:

Natural sound.

Visual complexity without digital overload.

Physical activity.

Cooler microclimate.

Attention restoration.

Social recreation.

Distance from urban stressors.

The nervous system doesn't need to know the theory.

Sit by water.

Listen.

Watch the movement.

17. GROUNDING / EARTHING

Two different things get called grounding.

PSYCHOLOGICAL GROUNDING

Strongly defensible.

Barefoot sensation.

Feeling floor pressure.

Touching textures.

Orienting visually.

Naming sensory information.

This increases immediate somatosensory/proprioceptive input and shifts attention toward the present environment.

ELECTRICAL “EARTHING”

Claims that direct contact with Earth transfers electrons into the body and thereby treats inflammation, sleep disorders or chronic disease have generated small studies, but the evidence base remains limited and controversial.

So:

Walking barefoot on safe grass may absolutely feel regulating.

But don't tell someone that shoes are electrically poisoning them or that earthing is an established medical treatment.

PRACTICE

Stand barefoot safely.

Feel:

Heel.

Outer foot.

Ball of foot.

Toes.

Shift weight slowly.

Let the brain map the ground.

18. SHAKING & “WAKING THE TIGER”

Peter Levine's Somatic Experiencing framework emphasizes completing defensive responses and attending carefully to bodily sensations after trauma.

There is some emerging clinical evidence for Somatic Experiencing as an overall therapeutic approach. One randomized controlled trial involving 63 participants with PTSD found

significant symptom improvements, although more research is needed.

But this does not prove the stronger popular claim that deliberately shaking literally “discharges trauma stored in the nervous system” in a known biological way.

That's a conceptual model.

WHAT SHAKING DEFINITELY DOES

Produces intense proprioceptive input.

Moves chronically tense muscles.

Changes breathing.

Interrupts frozen posture.

Changes sensory state.

Can feel cathartic.

SAFE PRACTICE

Stand securely.

Shake hands.

Then arms.

Shoulders.

One leg.

Other leg.

Whole body lightly.

30–90 seconds.

Stop.

Notice.

The key isn't forcing dramatic tremors.

It's letting movement replace immobility.

19. TRAUMA STATES: MOBILIZE OR DOWNSHIFT

Not every distressed nervous system needs calming.

Sometimes the person is:

Agitated.

Panicked.

Hyperalert.

Then choose:

Yoga Nidra.

Slow sound.

Weight.

Warmth.

Stretching.

Massage.

Longer exhalation.

Sometimes the person is:

Collapsed.

Numb.

Frozen.

Heavy.

Disconnected.

Then overly sedating practices may feel worse.

Try:

Morning sunlight.

Walking.

Shaking.

Rhythmic music.

Qigong.

Cool water.

Food.

Social contact.

The useful question is not:

“How do I calm down?”

It is:

“Am I overactivated or underactivated?”

Then regulate toward the middle.

20. BRAIN-DUMP JOURNALING

This is different from reflective journaling.

When overloaded, working memory becomes occupied by:

Things to remember.

Threats.

Arguments.

Plans.

Tasks.

Questions.

Possible outcomes.

Put everything onto paper.

No grammar.

No interpretation.

No narrative.

Just:

CALL ____

PAY ____

WORRIED ABOUT ____

NEED FOOD

EMAIL ____

CAN'T STOP THINKING ABOUT ____

Then draw three headings:

ACTIONABLE

NOT ACTIONABLE TODAY

UNKNOWN

Your brain no longer has to continuously rehearse everything simply to avoid forgetting it.

21. FOOD FOR RECOVERY: WHY IT MATTERS TO THE BRAIN

The brain is metabolically expensive.

Although it's only a fraction of body mass, it requires continuous energy and oxygen delivery.

Recovery requires:

Glucose availability.

Amino acids.

Fatty acids.

Minerals.

Vitamins.

Hydration.

Under-eating can produce:

Fatigue.

Weakness.

Irritability.

Poor concentration.

Sleep disturbance.

Feeling shaky or wired.

SIMPLE RECOVERY MEAL

Don't obsess over “superfoods.”

Build:

PROTEIN + CARBOHYDRATE + FAT + PLANT

Examples:

Eggs + potatoes + vegetables.

Beans + rice + avocado/oil.

Chicken + rice + frozen vegetables.

Peanut butter + oatmeal + banana.

Tuna + bread + fruit.

Yogurt + oats + nuts.

22. MAGNESIUM

Magnesium is genuinely involved in nervous-system and muscular physiology.

The body requires it for:

Nerve function.

Muscle contraction/relaxation.

Blood pressure regulation.

Glucose regulation.

Protein synthesis.

DNA.

Long-term magnesium deficiency can cause fatigue, weakness, cramps, neurological symptoms and abnormal heart rhythms.

FOOD SOURCES

Pumpkin seeds.

Chia seeds.

Almonds.

Peanuts.

Beans.

Whole grains.

Leafy greens.

Dark chocolate.

SUPPLEMENTS

A supplement isn't automatically useful simply because someone is stressed.

Supplemental magnesium can cause diarrhea and interacts with some medications.

Food-first is inexpensive and lower risk.

23. IRON & FATIGUE

Iron deserves special attention when persistent fatigue is involved.

Iron is necessary to make hemoglobin, which carries oxygen through the blood, and myoglobin, which helps supply oxygen to muscles.

Iron-deficiency anemia can produce:

Weakness.

Fatigue.

Poor concentration.

Reduced exercise tolerance.

Difficulty regulating temperature.

FOOD SOURCES

Meat.

Shellfish.

Beans.

Lentils.

Fortified cereals.

Spinach/leafy greens.

Plant iron is generally absorbed less efficiently than iron from animal foods.

Vitamin C eaten with plant iron can improve absorption.

DON'T BLINDLY TAKE HIGH-DOSE IRON

Iron overdose can be dangerous, especially to children.

Persistent fatigue is a reason to test, not merely guess.

24. VITAMIN B12 & FATIGUE

B12 is important for:

Red blood-cell formation.

DNA synthesis.

Neurological function.

Deficiency can produce:

Fatigue.

Weakness.

Numbness/tingling.

Balance problems.

Memory/cognitive symptoms.

Sources include:

Meat.

Fish.

Eggs.

Dairy.

Fortified foods.

Vegans are particularly dependent on fortified foods or supplementation because reliable natural plant sources are limited.

25. HERBS & TEAS

Think of herbs in three categories.

GENTLE FOOD-LIKE / TEA PRACTICES

Chamomile.

Ginger.

Peppermint.

Lemon balm.

Lavender.

These can create:

Warmth.

Hydration.

Aroma.

Ritual.

Behavioral slowing.

Some also contain biologically active compounds.

STRONGER HERBAL PRODUCTS

These deserve more caution.

“Natural” compounds can:

Sedate.

Alter blood pressure.

Affect liver enzymes.

Alter blood clotting.

Interact with medication.

So don't create a 12-herb nervous-system stack simply because every bottle says “calm.”

26. AROMA & THE BRAIN

Smell has unusually direct connections with brain systems involved in emotion and memory.

That's one reason odor can instantly evoke a state or memory before conscious reasoning catches up.

Aromatherapy evidence is mixed. NCCIH notes preliminary evidence around lavender and anxiety/sleep, but stronger trials are still needed.

CHEAP AROMATIC TOOLS

Peel an orange.

Crush rosemary.

Make peppermint tea.

Smell coffee.

Use a familiar soap.

Lavender sachet.

ESSENTIAL OILS

Use cautiously.

Don't drink them.

Dilute appropriately before skin use.

Stop if irritated.

Keep away from children/pets when the specific oil poses a risk.

27. CRYSTALS & STONES

Scientifically, crystals are beautiful minerals with genuine physical properties.

Quartz really is piezoelectric.

Magnetite really is magnetic.

Different minerals really have measurable crystal structures.

What has not been established is that carrying a particular crystal reliably treats trauma, fatigue, electromagnetic injury or disease through a special healing-energy field.

Still, crystals can work very well as symbolic/sensory anchors.

BLACK TOURMALINE

Traditional symbolism:

Protection.

Grounding.

Boundary.

SMOKY QUARTZ

Grounding.

Release.

AMETHYST

Calm.

Sleep.

Contemplation.

HEMATITE

Weight.

Grounding.

Physical presence.

CLEAR QUARTZ

Focus.

Intention.

ROSE QUARTZ

Compassion.

Safety.

Gentleness.

HOW TO MAKE THE PRACTICE PSYCHOLOGICALLY USEFUL

Don't just leave twenty stones on a shelf.

Choose one.

Assign it a job:

When I touch this, I stop and check my breathing.

Now it becomes a conditioned cue.

That mechanism is plausible.

28. BIOFEEDBACK

Biofeedback is basically making invisible physiology visible.

Sensors can measure:

Heart rate.

HRV.

Breathing.

Skin conductance.

Muscle tension.

Temperature.

Brain electrical activity in specialized neurofeedback contexts.

Then you deliberately practice changing your state and watch what happens.

This creates a feedback loop:

ACTION → PHYSIOLOGICAL CHANGE → VISUAL FEEDBACK → LEARNING

You begin discovering:

“Slow exhale actually changes my heart pattern.”

“My shoulders tense before I consciously feel stressed.”

“This music calms me; that one doesn't.”

NCCIH includes biofeedback among mind-body approaches studied for stress and other conditions, though evidence depends on the specific application.

LOW-COST BIOFEEDBACK

Even a basic smartwatch can sometimes show:

Resting heart rate.

Breathing.

Sleep trends.

Some HRV metrics.

Do not obsess over minute-to-minute numbers.

The goal is learning patterns, not becoming frightened by every fluctuation.

29. ACUPUNCTURE

Acupuncture stimulates peripheral tissues and nerves at specific points using very fine needles.

Research suggests potential usefulness for some pain conditions, while evidence for anxiety/fatigue and many other advertised applications remains mixed.

Possible mechanisms under investigation include:

Peripheral nerve stimulation.

Pain modulation.

Endogenous opioid signaling.

Central sensory processing.

Autonomic effects.

It should be regarded as adjunctive care, not universal medicine.

Look for:

Licensed practitioner.

Sterile single-use needles.

Community acupuncture clinics for lower prices.

30. MASSAGE

Massage changes sensory input on a massive scale.

Skin receptors.

Pressure receptors.

Muscles.

Fascia.

Joint positioning.

Temperature.

Interpersonal touch.

All send information into the nervous system.

Clinical research suggests massage can provide short-term improvements in some kinds of pain and may help anxiety or fatigue in certain populations, although evidence is inconsistent and mechanisms remain incompletely understood.

LOW-COST VERSIONS

Self-massage.

Massage school clinics.

Tennis ball against wall.

Foam roller.

Scalp massage.

Foot massage.

Hand massage.

Partner shoulder massage.

Don't aggressively massage an acute injury, blood clot, infection, unexplained swelling or other medically concerning area.

31. NATURE EXPOSURE

Nature isn't just “pretty scenery.”

Natural environments alter the entire sensory field:

Different sound spectrum.

Different visual patterns.

Less screen-based attentional demand.

Temperature variation.

Movement.

Sunlight.

Smell.

Research reviews suggest nature-based interventions may reduce stress, anxiety and depressive symptoms, although methods vary substantially.

DON'T TURN IT INTO ANOTHER PERFORMANCE

You don't need:

10,000 steps.

A mountain.

A \$300 hiking setup.

Sit underneath a tree.

Put your back against it.

Listen.

Walk around the block where trees grow.

Watch birds.

Go near water.

32. A SCIENCE-INFORMED RECOVERY SEQUENCE

If someone feels wired, exhausted and unable to shut down, I'd sequence the tools rather than throw everything at the body simultaneously.

MORNING

Outdoor light.

Water.

Protein/carbohydrate breakfast.

5–10 minutes Qigong or walking.

Gentle stretching.

MIDDAY

Real meal.

Outdoor movement.

Hydration.

Nature if available.

Avoid spending the entire day horizontal unless medically necessary—the circadian system needs a distinction between daytime activity and nighttime rest.

LATE AFTERNOON

Stretching.

Massage/foam rolling.

Tai chi.

Moderate exercise if enough energy exists.

EVENING

Warm bath/salt bath.

Lower lighting.

Less stimulating sound.

Humming/chanting.

Weighted blanket or deep pressure if it feels good.

Tea.

BED

Yoga Nidra.

Singing bowls or slow music.

Cool, dark room.

No requirement to “succeed” at sleeping.

IF YOU WAKE AND CAN'T RETURN TO SLEEP

Don't turn the bed into a battlefield.

Low light.

Yoga Nidra.

Slow humming.

Gentle body scan.

Return to sleep when sleepiness returns.

THE CENTRAL PRINCIPLE

The nervous system is continuously answering:

What time is it?

Am I nourished?

Am I physically safe enough to stop mobilizing?

What is touching me?

What am I hearing?

How am I breathing?

What are my muscles doing?

Am I moving?

Am I alone?

What does this environment mean?

That's why seemingly unrelated practices—sunlight, chanting, stretching, water, weighted blankets, food, Qigong, massage, nature—can all affect subjective nervous-system state.

They're changing different streams of information entering the same organism.

And that's the way I'd use holistic medicine scientifically:

not “one mystical thing heals everything,” but many small physiological inputs collectively changing the state the body is operating in.